

Hence, not only will you be able to use this programme for the pleasure of hearing a “hello world” from your computer, you will be able to modify this code to allow it to say more than just that.

This example of course, was overly simplistic. Even if the programme had been proprietary, anyone could recreate it making it immaterial whether it was open source or not. However, in today’s era of programmes that run up to tens of thousands of lines of code, with complex algorithms and databases forming an integral part of the system, it is impossible to recreate the code from observing how a program functions. Here, open source makes all the difference.

The Open Source Initiative, an organisation committed to promoting open source uses the open source definition in order to determine if a software is open source or not. This definition, among other things specifies requirements of the licence such as preventing discrimination against any persons or groups and preventing discrimination against fields of endeavour.

One must not forget that there is a core difference between open source and free software. While they both embody the same core idea, the former still allows the commercial utilisation of the code with the motive of profit. Many companies such as Red Hat gain significant revenues from sale, distribution, maintenance and consultancy services provided on open source software.

1.1 A history of open source

While the term open source has been coined only recently in 1998, the core concept behind it has been existent ever since the advent of software.

In the ‘50s and ‘60s, when computers and software were confined to academic and specialised industrial environments, almost all software was essentially open source. Software was not viewed as a commodity and the source code for most programs were as freely available as the programs themselves. This was due to the fact that in those days the community of developers and users of software was more or less the same. The users often modified the code to fix bugs or to improve functionality and use it themselves.

Most operating systems were freely distributed along with